NRItoUSA.com

THE 2026 EDITION · U.S. → INDIA RELOCATION

The Ultimate Return-to-India **Playbook**

The complete personal, financial & tax checklist for NRIs moving back home — with the tools to make each decision.

20 chapters | 60+ decision points | 25+ linked calculators

Who this playbook is for

H-1B, L-1, green card, and U.S.-citizen families planning a move back to India — this year or a decade from now. Tick each box and use the linked NRItoUSA.com tools to price the big decisions: 401(k), RNOR timing, property and repatriation.

Scan for the free hub & all calculators

Start free at nritousa.com/return-to-india

HOW TO USE THIS PLAYBOOK

Your move-back command centre

Returning to India is not one decision — it is fifty smaller ones spread across your job, your bank accounts, your retirement plan, your taxes in **two** countries, your property and your family. Miss the sequencing and the mistakes can be expensive: an unnecessary 401(k) cash-out, a missed RNOR opportunity, a closed U.S. credit history that is hard to rebuild, or a tax filing you did not know you still owed.

This playbook walks through all twenty areas in a sensible order. Each chapter gives you a short brief, a tick-box checklist, and — where a real choice is involved — a **Decision Point** that links to the free NRItoUSA.com calculator or guide that helps you put numbers behind it. Work top to bottom, or jump to the chapter you need. Print it, or keep it open on your phone.

⚠ Before you use this playbook

This playbook is a **decision checklist, not professional advice.** U.S.–India tax, immigration, FEMA/RBI, retirement, and Social Security rules can change and can vary by citizenship, visa status, green card history, state residency, account type, and family situation. Use this guide to organize your questions, then verify current rules with official **IRS, SSA, USCIS, FinCEN, Income Tax India, RBI/FEMA**, and bank sources before taking action.

Last reviewed: 2026. Always confirm current rules before acting.

⚑ Start with the two questions that change everything

Your **move date** and your **India tax-residency timeline (RNOR)** influence many financial and tax choices that follow — when to sell property, when to consider a Roth conversion, when to realise gains, and when your U.S. income may first become taxable in India. Pin these down early.

▸ Model your India tax-residency timeline with the RNOR Calculator

What's inside

A BIRD'S-EYE VIEW OF THE MOVE

Return-to-India timeline

Every family's situation differs, so treat this as a general sequence rather than a fixed rulebook. Dates shift with visa status, employer timelines, and the Indian financial year — confirm the specifics for your case.

12+ months before move

- Model RNOR / tax residency and pick a target move window
- Decide U.S. home: sell vs. rent
- Review 401(k), IRA, brokerage, and equity (RSU/ESPP/options)
- Start school and city research in India

6 months before move

- Confirm visa / green card / OCI strategy
- Review bank and brokerage non-resident policies
- Build a tax reserve and relocation budget
- Start collecting documents and statements

3 months before move

- Plan final paycheck, bonus, PTO, and RSU/options timing
- Review COBRA vs. India health insurance
- Prepare FBAR / FATCA / India tax records
- Confirm U.S. phone, MFA, and account access

30 days before move

- Download all records (7 years of returns, statements, policies)
- Move MFA off U.S. SMS where possible
- Confirm transfers, rent/sale, utilities, and insurance
- Keep a U.S. bank and a no-fee credit card active if appropriate

First 90 days in India

- Complete PAN / Aadhaar / KYC / UPI setup where applicable
- Confirm bank-account redesignation requirements with your bank
- Put India health insurance in force
- Keep your U.S. tax calendar visible
- Avoid rushing into Indian mutual funds or insurance-investment products before understanding tax impact

i Timing note

RNOR is an income-tax concept; bank-account status is a FEMA concept; and immigration status is separate again. They do not always line up. Confirm each with the right authority or advisor rather than assuming one status controls the others.

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6–12 MONTHS BEFORE THE MOVE

Planning your timeline

The move-back is a project with a critical path. Lock your dates first, because your employment end date and your India arrival date set the clock on taxes, residency, notice periods, lease-breaks and school terms.

6–12 mo	~2–3 yrs*	2 tax systems
ideal planning runway	possible RNOR window	to reconcile

- ☐ Fix a target **move date** and a **final employment day** — much of the plan schedules backwards from these.
- ☐ Build a relocation budget: shipping/air freight, one-way flights, India housing deposit, a 3–6 month emergency buffer, and a tax reserve.
- ☐ Confirm each family member's immigration status and travel documents (passport validity 6+ months, visas, OCI/U.S. passports for children).
- ☐ Decide the fate of your U.S. home and car early — sale timelines can run in months, not weeks.
- ☐ Map your India landing: city, interim housing, schools, and which relative or contact is your local anchor.
- ☐ Open a shared tracker for every account, policy and document you'll need to close, keep or transfer.

i What RNOR may (and may not) do

RNOR status **may reduce** Indian tax exposure on **certain** foreign income for a limited period after returning, depending on your prior India stay history, arrival date, source of income, and whether income is received in India. It is not an automatic shield on all foreign income.

⚑ Decision Point — time the move around your India tax residency

Arriving a few weeks either side of a financial-year boundary can change whether your first years back qualify as **RNOR** (when certain foreign income may remain outside India's tax net, depending on the facts). *Duration depends on your facts and prior India presence.

▸ **Run your dates through the RNOR / Tax-Residency Calculator**

⚡ If the move is being forced by a layoff

On H-1B you may have a limited window to act. Separate the immigration clock from the relocation clock so neither surprises you.

▸ **Open the H-1B Layoff checklist**

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CLOSE IT OUT CLEANLY

Employment & your final paycheck

Your employer is the source of documents you'll want for years — collect them while you still have a badge, an active email and a friendly HR contact.

- ☐ Give notice per your contract; confirm your **last working day** and final-settlement date in writing.
- ☐ Download final payslips, the latest and prior-year **W-2s**, and an employment-verification letter.
- ☐ Get written detail on **RSU/ESPP/options**: vesting, blackout, exercise windows and post-termination expiry.
- ☐ Clarify bonus, PTO payout, and any sign-on/relocation clawbacks that leaving may trigger.
- ☐ Decide on **COBRA** vs. a marketplace/India plan for the coverage gap — note the election deadline (often 60 days).
- ☐ Roll over or note your **401(k)** and **HSA** details (plan administrator, login, balances) before access is cut.
- ☐ Save copies of everything to personal storage; you will likely lose corporate email and SSO on your last day.

→ Decision Point — don't let vested equity expire by accident

Post-termination exercise windows for options are often short (commonly around 90 days, but check your plan). Map every grant's expiry against your move date and your cash position before you hand back the laptop.

▸ **See how RSUs/options fit your cross-border wealth picture**

3

THE HIGHEST-STAKES CHAPTER

Tax planning across the U.S. & India

Depending on your citizenship, green card status, visa status, and tax residency, you may file a final, dual-status, or part-year U.S. return — or continue annual U.S. filing after moving. U.S. citizens and some green card holders may continue to have U.S. filing obligations even while living in India. The goal is to avoid double taxation using the DTAA and foreign tax credits, and to stay compliant with reporting that can follow you abroad.

RNOR	DTAA	FBAR/8938
may reduce foreign-income tax	may avoid double tax	may apply abroad

U.S. side

- ☐ Plan your **final, dual-status, or part-year** federal and state returns; confirm residency-termination dates where relevant.
- ☐ Gather W-2s, 1099s, brokerage 1099-B, K-1s and full investment cost-basis records.
- ☐ Understand **FBAR (FinCEN 114)** and **FATCA (Form 8938)** — these may continue after you leave if thresholds are met.
- ☐ Watch **PFIC** exposure if you hold or plan to hold Indian mutual funds while a U.S. taxpayer.
- ☐ If you'll keep U.S. rental property or a business, plan for continued U.S. filing on that income.

→ Decision Point — will your India accounts create U.S. paperwork?

NRE, NRO, FDs, brokerage, and Indian mutual funds may trigger FBAR, Form 8938, or PFIC reporting if you remain a U.S. person for tax purposes. Check before balances grow.

▸ Run the FBAR / FATCA risk checker

i Quick reporting check

- **FBAR / FinCEN Form 114:** U.S. persons generally must file if the aggregate value of foreign financial accounts exceeds **$10,000** at any time during the calendar year.
- **Form 8938 / FATCA:** thresholds depend on filing status and whether you live in the U.S. or abroad — check before balances grow.
- Indian accounts such as NRE, NRO, FDs, brokerage, and mutual funds may create U.S. reporting obligations if you remain a U.S. person for tax purposes.

⚠ State tax residency can be sticky

Some states — especially **CA, NY, NJ, and IL** — make it harder to end residency, and may continue to treat you as a resident after you leave. Confirm your state exit rules before leaving.

India side

- ☐ Track your India residency status (**NRI → RNOR → ROR**) for each financial year after arrival.
- ☐ Line up **PAN**, and coordinate account redesignation timing with your bank (see the banking chapter).
- ☐ Map India-source income (rent, FD interest, capital gains) and any **TDS** you may later reclaim.
- ☐ Keep **Form 10F**, a tax-residency certificate, and 15CA/15CB paperwork ready for repatriations.

→ Decision Point — claim treaty relief instead of paying twice

Where the same income is taxed in both countries, the DTAA and the Foreign Tax Credit may reduce or eliminate the double hit — but generally only if you compute and document it correctly.

▸ Estimate relief with the DTAA / Foreign-Tax-Credit Calculator

→ Not sure where to even start filing?

A guided roadmap can help you sequence your U.S. and India filings, forms and deadlines so nothing slips between the two systems.

▸ Open the DIY NRI Tax-Filing Roadmap

→ Keep the two-country form list on hand

One place with the U.S. and India forms, thresholds and deadlines that commonly apply to returning NRIs.

▸ See the NRI Tax Forms & Limits Center

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KEEP A U.S. FOOTPRINT; SET UP INDIA

Banking on both sides

Don't reflexively close everything American. A maintained U.S. account and card can be hard to reopen from abroad and are useful for lingering tax refunds, brokerage links and future travel.

- ☐ Decide which U.S. checking/savings to **keep open** (ideally no-fee, no minimum, good online/app access).
- ☐ Update the address, phone and email on kept accounts to ones you'll still control from India.
- ☐ Enable full online/mobile access and confirm international login works before you fly.
- ☐ Set up or update your India **NRE / NRO** accounts; understand which income each is meant to hold.
- ☐ Coordinate NRE/NRO redesignation with your bank based on **FEMA residential status**, your return-to-India intent, and bank documentation rules — do not rely only on income-tax RNOR/ROR status.
- ☐ Note where refunds, dividends and any Social Security could still land, and keep that account alive.

⚠ Banking status and tax residency are not the same

India income-tax residency categories such as **NRI, RNOR, and ROR** do not always line up perfectly with **FEMA/banking residential status**. Confirm with your bank and tax advisor before converting or redesignating NRE/NRO accounts.

→ Decision Point — which account for which rupee?

NRE interest is generally tax-free in India but may still be taxable in the U.S.; NRO typically holds India-source income and is taxed in India. Getting the mapping right helps avoid surprise tax and reporting.

▸ **Read NRE vs. NRO accounts explained**

→ Parking a lump sum? Compare the yield honestly

Before locking money into an FCNR deposit, compare the after-tax return against a U.S. high-yield savings account or CD.

▸ **Compare with the FCNR vs. HYSA Calculator**

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BEFORE YOU BECOME A NON-RESIDENT

Investments & brokerage

Many U.S. brokerages restrict or freeze accounts held by non-U.S. residents. Sort out access, beneficiaries and any planned sales while your U.S. address is still valid.

- ☐ Ask each brokerage its **non-resident policy** — can you hold, trade, or only sell? Get it in writing.
- ☐ Update **beneficiaries** and transfer-on-death designations across all accounts.
- ☐ Review whether to realise gains/losses before leaving, considering U.S. and India treatment and your residency timeline.
- ☐ Consolidate scattered accounts; record logins, statements and full cost basis.
- ☐ Think twice before buying Indian mutual funds while still a U.S. taxpayer (PFIC complexity).
- ☐ Revisit your long-term split between U.S. and India assets given currency and inflation.

→ Decision Point — the Indian mutual fund trap

Indian mutual funds are generally treated as **PFICs** for U.S. tax purposes, with complex forms and tax treatment. Understand this before you invest.

▸ **Read: the PFIC / Indian mutual fund trap**

→ Where should new money go — U.S. or India?

Currency, inflation, taxes and where you'll actually spend all pull in different directions. Frame the trade-offs deliberately.

▸ **Read: invest more in the USA or India?**

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AVOID THE MOST EXPENSIVE REFLEX

401(k) & employer retirement

Your 401(k) does not vanish when you leave the U.S. Cashing it out early is one of the costliest reflexes for returning NRIs — tax, a possible penalty, and lost compounding can stack up fast.

10%	Varies	$0
possible extra tax if <59½*	withholding by plan/treaty	direct 401(k)→NPS/PPF pipe

Your four real options

- ☐ **Leave it invested** in the U.S. plan (if allowed) and let it compound in USD.
- ☐ **Roll over** to an IRA for more control and investment choice.
- ☐ **Roth conversion** — potentially during a lower-income year — to help manage lifetime tax.
- ☐ **Cash out** — often the least attractive option before 59½ due to tax, a possible penalty, and lost growth.

i How withholding and penalties actually work

Withholding can vary by plan, distribution type, tax residency, treaty documentation, and whether the distribution is eligible for rollover. Early distributions before age 59½ may also trigger a **10% additional tax** unless an exception applies. *Confirm your specifics before acting.

→ Decision Point — cash out now vs. keep compounding

Model the after-tax, after-penalty lump sum against leaving it invested in USD toward retirement. The gap is often large. Do not reflexively cash out your 401(k).

▸ **Run the 401(k) Cash-Out vs. Keep Calculator**

→ "Can I just move it to NPS or PPF?"

There is no direct transfer pipe from a U.S. 401(k) into Indian retirement accounts — but there are legitimate approaches worth understanding.

▸ **Read: what happens to your 401(k) + the NPS/PPF reality**

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A LOW-INCOME YEAR CAN BE AN OPPORTUNITY

IRA — Roth vs. Traditional

Beyond the 401(k), IRAs give you control — and the years around your move (often lower U.S. income) can be a good time to consider strategic Roth conversions. Whether it helps depends on your facts.

- ☐ Inventory all IRAs: **Traditional, Roth, SEP, and any inherited** IRAs, with balances and custodians.
- ☐ Consider whether a **Roth conversion** in a lower-income transition year may lower lifetime tax.
- ☐ Confirm your custodian still services non-resident IRA holders and update contact details.
- ☐ Refresh beneficiaries and understand distribution rules before and after age 59½.
- ☐ Coordinate IRA moves with your 401(k) plan so the whole retirement picture is consistent.

→ Decision Point — Roth or Traditional as an NRI?

The right answer generally depends on your current vs. future tax rates in both countries and your residency timing.

▸ **Read: Roth IRA vs. Traditional IRA for NRIs**

→ High earner phased out of Roth?

Check whether a clean backdoor Roth may be available to you — and mind the pro-rata rule.

▸ **Use the Backdoor Roth eligibility calculator**

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CREDITS YOU EARNED, BENEFITS TO VERIFY

Social Security & Medicare

Work credits don't disappear when you move. But there is no U.S.–India totalization agreement, and Medicare generally will not help you in India — so understand both before you leave.

- ☐ Check your **credit count** at ssa.gov — **40 credits (~10 years)** generally qualifies you for retirement benefits.
- ☐ Confirm how, and to which account, benefits could be paid while you live in India, based on your citizenship status.
- ☐ Note there is **no U.S.–India totalization treaty**, so U.S. and Indian systems don't combine credits.
- ☐ Understand **Medicare Part A/B** value if you'll live abroad, and any late-enrolment implications if you return.
- ☐ **Medicare generally does not cover routine care in India** — do not treat Medicare as your India health plan.
- ☐ Keep your SSA online login, earnings record, and mailing details current.

⚠ Payments abroad depend on your status

Social Security payment-abroad rules differ for U.S. citizens and non-U.S. citizens. U.S. citizens may generally receive benefits abroad, but noncitizens may face restrictions after extended time outside the U.S. unless an exception applies. Do not assume benefits will continue in India without checking SSA's **Payments Abroad** rules for your exact status.

→ Decision Point — will you actually collect Social Security in India?

The 40-credit rule, payment-abroad rules for your status, and recent law changes all affect the answer. Get clear before you count on it.

▸ **Read: do you keep Social Security if you return to India?**

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A HISTORY THAT'S HARD TO REBUILD FROM INDIA

Credit & loans

Your U.S. credit score can't be exported and can be painful to rebuild if you ever return. Preserve a thread of it, and unwind loans on your terms.

- ☐ Keep at least one old, **no-fee** credit card open to help preserve U.S. credit history and length.
- ☐ Set autopay from a kept U.S. account and monitor for fraud while abroad.
- ☐ Download full **credit reports** from all three bureaus before you go.
- ☐ Pay off or plan the handling of auto loans, student loans and any personal lines.
- ☐ Close only what carries fees or risk; leaving a small footprint open is often worth it.
- ☐ Update contact info with lenders so nothing goes to collections unnoticed.

→ **Why keep a U.S. card at all?**

Length of history and available credit are common score factors. A dormant no-fee card may quietly protect both — useful if you return, travel, or keep U.S. ties.

▸ **Banking & credit guides for immigrants**

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U.S. PROPERTY, U.S. CAR — AND INDIA PROPERTY

Home & vehicle

Selling or renting real estate and disposing of a vehicle both run on multi-month timelines. Start early, and if you own property in India, plan that sale with the tax math up front.

In the U.S.

- ☐ Decide **sell vs. rent** your U.S. home; model it against how long you'd realistically keep it.
- ☐ Line up an agent or property manager; schedule repairs, staging or tenant screening now.
- ☐ Schedule utility, internet, and service terminations for just after your departure.
- ☐ Sell, ship or export the car; cancel registration and auto insurance on the right dates.
- ☐ If you'll keep the home as a rental, plan for continued U.S. tax filing on that income.

→ **Decision Point — rent vs. buy/keep on a visa horizon**

Standard calculators often assume 30 years. This one ties the decision to your real relocation horizon, including selling costs.

▸ **Use the Rent vs. Buy (visa) calculator**

Property in India

- ☐ Decide **sell before or after** the move, weighing capital-gains tax, TDS and repatriation rules.
- ☐ Gather title, chain documents, and establish your cost basis for both India and U.S. reporting.
- ☐ Understand the **54EC** exemption route and the repatriation limits that may apply.

→ **Decision Point — the true after-tax proceeds of an India sale**

Estimate capital gains, TDS, the 54EC exemption and how much you may be able to repatriate — in one place.

▸ **Use the India Property Sale Calculator**

→ **Selling India property specifically to fund retirement?**

There are timing and tax angles worth reading before you list.

▸ **Read: selling India property before retirement**

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CLOSE GAPS; DON'T ABANDON YOUR HSA

Insurance & HSA

Coverage gaps during a move are risky, and your HSA is a long-term account you keep for life. Review every policy and every balance.

- ☐ Review **health** coverage for the transition (COBRA vs. marketplace vs. India plan) and the exact gap dates.
- ☐ Line up robust **India health insurance** before U.S. coverage lapses — pre-existing waiting periods matter.
- ☐ Review **life, disability, auto, renters/home** policies; cancel or convert on the right dates.
- ☐ Don't forget your **HSA** — you generally keep it after leaving the U.S.; understand how to spend it and the cross-border tax treatment.
- ☐ Check travel/medical cover for the actual move and the first weeks in India.

→ Decision Point — what happens to your HSA abroad?

Your Health Savings Account generally remains yours, even in India — but the way you spend it and its cross-border tax treatment need care.

▸ **Read: can you keep your HSA after leaving the U.S.?**

→ Insurance guides in one place

Health, life, auto and disability basics for immigrant families.

▸ **Browse insurance guides**

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I-407, GREEN CARDS, OCI

Immigration & status

Keep pristine copies of your entire immigration record, and make the green-card and OCI decisions deliberately — they can have long tails for you and your children.

- ☐ Preserve copies of **I-94, I-797, visas, passport stamps**, and green card (front and back).
- ☐ If surrendering a green card, understand **Form I-407** and possible **exit-tax** exposure for long-term residents.
- ☐ If keeping a green card while abroad, know the re-entry and abandonment rules (and re-entry permit timing).
- ☐ For U.S.-citizen family members, check **OCI** eligibility and apply in good time — it can ease living in India long-term.
- ☐ Keep children's **U.S. passports/CRBA** and Indian documents together and current.
- ☐ Note current processing times so renewals and OCI applications don't bottleneck your move.

→ Decision Point — OCI for your U.S.-citizen children (and you)

OCI can make long-term life in India far smoother. Check who qualifies, then estimate cost and timeline before you fly.

▸ **Check OCI eligibility**

→ Renewing documents before the move

Estimate OCI cost and timeline, green-card renewal, or Indian passport renewal so nothing expires mid-transition.

▸ **OCI cost & timeline and renewal guides**

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DOCUMENTS, CONTINUITY, LONG-TERM LEGACY

Children & education

Schools in India ask for paperwork U.S. families don't always keep. Collect it now, plan the academic transition, and think ahead about assets your U.S.-raised kids may one day inherit.

- ☐ Collect **transcripts, report cards, and completion/transfer certificates** from current schools.
- ☐ Gather **immunisation/vaccination records** in a format Indian schools and doctors accept.
- ☐ Research Indian school boards (CBSE/ICSE/IB/IGCSE) and admission timelines for your city.
- ☐ Decide what to do with **529 plans** — keep for future U.S. study, or repurpose within the rules.
- ☐ Keep children's U.S. and Indian identity documents together (passports, SSNs, and Aadhaar later where applicable).
- ☐ Plan the emotional/social transition, not just the logistics.

→ Decision Point — assets your U.S. kids may inherit in India

U.S.-raised children can struggle to manage inherited Indian property — paperwork, distance and disputes. Prepare early.

▸ **Read: why U.S. kids struggle with India property**

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YOU CAN'T ALWAYS REQUEST THESE AFTER YOU LEAVE

Documents to download & keep

Once corporate and some U.S. institutional access ends, retrieving records from abroad can be painful. Build one encrypted archive before departure.

- ☐ **Tax returns for 7 years**, plus all W-2s, 1099s and supporting schedules.
- ☐ Bank and brokerage **statements and full cost-basis** exports.
- ☐ Property papers, closing documents, mortgage payoff letters.
- ☐ All insurance policies and declarations pages.
- ☐ Immigration file, IDs, birth/marriage certificates, and children's records.
- ☐ Employer letters, final payslips, and retirement-account details/logins.
- ☐ Store as encrypted PDFs in at least two places (cloud + local), with a shared index.

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DON'T GET LOCKED OUT FROM 8,000 MILES AWAY

Digital accounts & security

Two-factor codes tied to a U.S. number can lock you out of critical accounts the moment you change your phone plan. Fix your digital identity before you move.

- ☐ Move MFA to an **authenticator app** and export/backup recovery codes for every critical login.
- ☐ Confirm access to email, banking, brokerage and government portals without a U.S. SMS number.
- ☐ Update your **password manager**, recovery email and trusted devices.
- ☐ Review and cancel subscriptions and auto-renewals you won't use from India.
- ☐ Keep a working U.S. number if needed (eSIM/port to a low-cost carrier) for account recovery.

16

PROTECT THE EXCHANGE-RATE MARGIN

Money transfers & repatriation

The headline “zero fee” on transfers often hides the real cost in the exchange-rate margin — and India's TCS can apply to certain outward remittances. Plan large moves deliberately.

- ☐ Compare providers on the **full** cost: flat fee + FX margin + any India **TCS** that may apply.
- ☐ Split or time large transfers around rate levels and your liquidity needs rather than moving everything at once.
- ☐ For repatriating India funds, prepare **Form 15CA/15CB** where applicable and confirm current limits.
- ☐ Keep **Form 10F** and a tax-residency certificate handy to help reduce excess TDS.
- ☐ Document the source of funds for every large transfer for both countries' records.

⚠ On the $1M figure

The **commonly referenced $1M annual NRO/property repatriation limit** is subject to taxes paid, documentation, bank review, RBI/FEMA rules, and Form 15CA/15CB where applicable. **Do not assume the full amount can be moved immediately without paperwork.**

→ Decision Point — what actually lands after fees, margin & TCS?

See the estimated true cost of a U.S.–India transfer, including hidden FX margin and any TCS, and the net amount that may arrive.

▸ **Use the Remittance & TCS Cost Calculator**

→ Repatriating a property sale or large NRO balance?

The 15CA/15CB paperwork and repatriation limits generally follow a specific sequence — don't improvise it.

▸ **Read: repatriating India property-sale funds**

17 LAND, REGISTER, ACTIVATE
Your first 90 days in India

The first three months are a setup sprint. Get your identity, banking and payments live, then layer on insurance and investments.

- ☐ Update or apply for **Aadhaar** if eligible/required, keep **PAN** active, and complete PAN–Aadhaar or bank KYC requirements where applicable.
- ☐ Bring bank accounts fully live and enable **UPI** for daily payments.
- ☐ Coordinate any NRE/NRO redesignation with your bank based on FEMA residential status and documentation rules — not on income-tax status alone.
- ☐ Put local **health insurance** in force and register with local doctors/hospitals.
- ☐ Set up utilities, mobile (KYC), rental agreement, and school admissions.
- ☐ Begin any India investments deliberately — avoid rushing into products before you understand the tax.
- ☐ Keep your U.S. tax calendar visible; you may still have filings and refunds pending.

> → **Keep the whole cross-border picture in one view**
> As U.S. and India accounts coexist, a single organiser can help keep beneficiaries, reporting and retirement aligned across both countries.
> ▸ **Start the free NRI Wealth Checkup**

18 LEARN THESE BEFORE, NOT AFTER
Common (expensive) mistakes

Almost every costly return-to-India error is avoidable and appears in this playbook. Here are the ones that tend to hurt most.

- ☐ Cashing out a 401(k) early — tax, a possible penalty, and lost compounding, often needlessly.
- ☐ Closing **all** U.S. accounts and cards, then being unable to reopen or rebuild credit.
- ☐ Missing a required U.S. tax filing (final, dual-status, or ongoing), or FBAR/FATCA duties after leaving.
- ☐ Ignoring **DTAA** and foreign-tax-credit relief and paying tax twice.
- ☐ Mis-timing the move and missing a possible RNOR benefit for certain foreign income.
- ☐ Redesignating NRE/NRO accounts based on income-tax status alone instead of FEMA/bank rules.
- ☐ Failing to download records while access is still open.

- ☐ Buying Indian mutual funds while still a U.S. taxpayer without understanding the PFIC cost.

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EVERY DECISION — ONE LINK

Your Return-to-India toolkit

Each big decision in this playbook has a free, no-signup NRItoUSA.com calculator or checker behind it. Tap any tool below to put real numbers on your situation.

RNOR / Tax-Residency
When might India tax your global income?
▸ Open tool

Backdoor Roth eligibility
Check the pro-rata rule before converting.
▸ Open tool

401(k) Cash-Out vs. Keep
Model tax + penalty vs. USD compounding.
▸ Open tool

DIY Tax-Filing Roadmap
Sequence your U.S. + India filings and forms.
▸ Open tool

⚖ DTAA / Foreign Tax Credit
Estimate relief and help avoid double tax.
▸ Open tool

Form 10F Generator
Prep treaty paperwork to help reduce excess TDS.
▸ Open tool

FBAR / FATCA Checker
Do your India accounts create U.S. paperwork?
▸ Open tool

15CA / 15CB Checklist
Repatriation paperwork, in order.
▸ Open tool

India Property Sale
Capital gains, TDS, 54EC and repatriation limits.
▸ Open tool

NRI TDS-Refund Checklist
Reclaim tax withheld on India income.
▸ Open tool

Remittance & TCS Cost
The estimated true cost of a U.S.–India transfer.
▸ Open tool

NRI Wealth Checkup
Map every U.S. + India asset in one place.
▸ Open tool

FCNR vs. HYSA
After-tax yield on an FCNR vs. a U.S. HYSA/CD.
▸ Open tool

OCI Eligibility Checker
For your U.S.-citizen family members.
▸ Open tool

Rent vs. Buy (visa)
Housing math tied to your relocation horizon.
▸ Open tool

✈ Flight Price Guide
Time your USA–India tickets.
▸ Open tool

→ See every tool and guide in one place

Twenty-five-plus free calculators and checklists for immigration, tax, wealth and the move back home.

▸ Browse all NRItoUSA.com tools

⚠ Who should get professional help before acting

This playbook is enough to organize your move, but some situations deserve professional review:

- Green card holder for 8+ years or possible U.S. exit-tax exposure
- U.S. citizen or green card family moving permanently to India
- Large 401(k), IRA, Roth conversion, or HSA balances
- RSUs, stock options, ESPP, or concentrated employer stock
- Indian mutual funds while still a U.S. taxpayer
- India property sale, inherited property, or large NRO repatriation
- U.S. rental property after moving to India
- Business ownership in the U.S. or India
- U.S.-citizen children inheriting Indian assets
- Sticky U.S. state tax residency issues (e.g. CA, NY, NJ, IL)

▸ Start with the NRI Wealth Checkup — then talk to a qualified cross-border CPA, attorney, or advisor before making irreversible decisions.

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YOUR ONE-PAGE CONTROL PANEL

The master checklist

Print this page. When every box is ticked — and you've verified the specifics for your situation — you're ready to fly.

- ☐ Move date & final employment day locked
- ☐ Relocation budget + tax reserve set aside
- ☐ RNOR / tax-residency timing modelled
- ☐ U.S. filing plan set (final / dual-status / ongoing)
- ☐ State exit / residency rules confirmed (CA/NY/NJ/IL etc.)
- ☐ FBAR / FATCA / PFIC exposure checked
- ☐ DTAA / foreign-tax-credit relief mapped
- ☐ U.S. bank + one no-fee card kept open
- ☐ NRE / NRO set up; redesignation coordinated with bank (FEMA)
- ☐ 401(k) decision made (not a reflex cash-out)
- ☐ IRA / Roth strategy set for transition years
- ☐ Social Security payments-abroad rules checked for your status
- ☐ HSA handling understood
- ☐ Brokerage non-resident policy + beneficiaries sorted
- ☐ U.S. home & car: sell/rent/export decided
- ☐ India property sale/hold planned with tax math
- ☐ All insurance reviewed; India health cover in force
- ☐ Immigration file copied; I-407 / OCI decided
- ☐ Children's transcripts, vaccines & 529 handled
- ☐ 7 years of documents downloaded & encrypted
- ☐ Digital MFA moved off U.S. SMS; subscriptions reviewed
- ☐ Large transfers planned around FX margin & TCS
- ☐ First-90-days setup ready (PAN, Aadhaar/KYC, UPI)
- ☐ Pro review booked for complex items (exit tax, RSUs, property)

Put real numbers behind every box

This playbook tells you **what** to decide. The free NRItoUSA.com tools help you estimate **how much** each choice may be worth — 401(k), RNOR timing, property, currency and repatriation.

▸ **Start the Return-to-India hub** · **Run the NRI Wealth Checkup**

Scan to open the free hub

i Want the editable checklist?

Download the free Google Sheet version of this Return-to-India checklist and get future 2026 rule updates by email.

▸ **Get the editable checklist**

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Official sources to verify before acting: IRS, FinCEN, SSA, USCIS, Income Tax India, RBI/FEMA guidance, and your bank/custodian's current non-resident policy.